

James Dishman

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SUMMARY

UX researcher and designer graduating with an MS in User Experience from Kent State University in December 2026, 3.95 GPA. I work across accessibility auditing, discovery research, title research, AI agent system design, and creativity support tools. Thirty years in electronic music production and a decade co-leading Pittsburgh's Ableton User Group help me evaluate expert workflows, cognitive demand, and the point where a powerful tool stops explaining itself.

SKILLS

Research Methods

Contextual inquiry · Semi-structured interviews · Moderated usability testing · Unmoderated usability testing · Cognitive walkthrough · Journey mapping · Affinity mapping · JTBD analysis · Card sorting · Paper prototyping · Survey design · Heuristic evaluation

Design & Tools

Figma · Photoshop · Miro · Obsidian · Adobe Acrobat · Google Forms · Loop11 · Lyssna

Accessibility

WCAG 2.1 AA/AAA · COGA cognitive accessibility · VoiceOver testing · Contrast analysis (WebAIM) · Readability analysis (Flesch-Kincaid) · PDF remediation · Universal design

Technical

HTML/CSS · Next.js · TypeScript · React Native / Expo · Python · Rust · p5.js · SQLite · RAG / vector search · GitHub Actions CI/CD · API integration · Google Analytics 4 · AI prompt design · Multi-agent system design

EXPERIENCE

Title Researcher

2026–Present

Oil and Gas Title Research

- Research property, lease, and ownership records for oil and gas title work
- Resolve ambiguous record histories through document review, cross-checking, and chain-of-title analysis
- Bring prior abstracting experience into a current research role focused on records, evidence, and defensible conclusions

Smart Meter Technician

April 2025–May 2026

Wellington Energy (FirstEnergy subcontractor)

- Conducted residential electrical service assessments at high volume across assigned territory, evaluating safety conditions before equipment exchange
- Communicated directly with residents to explain service interruptions and manage expectations during live infrastructure work
- Performed meter exchanges (analog to smart meter), documenting each site and escalating non-standard conditions for triage and resolution
- Worked independently across a distributed daily territory with no direct supervision, maintaining consistent safety and service standards

Graduate Assistant

2024–Present

Kent State University

- Developed instructional materials for graduate-level UX courses, improving course structure and student outcomes
- Assisted in authoring a graduate-level UX textbook through systematic analysis of academic publications and content development
- Conducted full site-map analysis and copy review across MS UX program web materials
- Verified qualitative research data for faculty projects

User Group Organizer

2015–Present

Pittsburgh Ableton User Group · Ableton AG

→

Co-founded and led community meetings for Ableton users across the Pittsburgh region, growing an active practitioner network (with Paul Miller and Steve Knots)

→

Served as direct liaison between user community and Ableton's international corporate team, channeling field feedback into product development cycles

→

Collaborated with university faculty and educators to expand music technology education access and inclusivity

Material Handler

2021–2023

Osmose Utility Services

→

Managed field logistics for steel and fiberglass pole repair crews across a Western Pennsylvania territory, coordinating material delivery to active utility job sites

→

Operated warehouse inventory and loaded trucks for distribution infrastructure restoration projects serving regional electric utilities

→

Gained direct exposure to electrical distribution system components, pole condition assessment workflows, and utility field operations

Self-employed Title Abstractor

2012–2019

Various Clients and Brokers

→

Conducted certified title analysis across multiple states and counties; managed complex multi-party research workflows

→

Led teams to resolve title defects through research, analysis, and resolution workflows

→

Partnered with attorneys on title opinions, delivering resolution on complex legal and property issues

EDUCATION

MS, User Experience · 3.95 GPA

Kent State University

December 2026

BA, English Writing

University of Pittsburgh

Related Studies: Philosophy, Political Science · Certificate in Latin American Studies

SELECTED PROJECTS

Clarence: AI Collaboration System →

2025–2026

Built Clarence on Hermes with governed SQLite memory, semantic retrieval, explicit write boundaries, bounded specialist handoffs, and public-safe telemetry. Used daily as a working research platform for human-AI collaboration.

SensorSynthFM →

2026

Active iPad FM synthesizer build with verified touch, accelerometer, gyro, and microphone modulation. Environmental mappings remain planned.

Ableton UX Evaluation Suite →

2024–2026

Multi-method evaluation across Ableton products, grounded in long-term music production experience and a decade co-leading Pittsburgh's Ableton User Group.

Usability Testing Methods →

2024–2026

Usability research collection anchored by a 15-participant moderated mobile study, with planning, facilitation, task analysis, and synthesis across multiple methods.